

Platt, and the question of how well the portfolio managers perform in general.

But after I left Mr. Lipper, I still didn't call Mr. Platt. Instead, I headed over to Salomon Brothers and got a tour of the trading room. Trading rooms are where decisions of the big institutions get carried out, and entire floors of expensive New York high-rises are given over to this activity. Salomon Brothers has one of the biggest trading operations, which is why I was anxious to see it.

This single firm takes a large chunk out of the square footage at 1 New York Plaza. Once I'd arrived downstairs, I got up the courage to visit my old college friend Brim, rumored to be making more than \$1 million a year as a managing partner. The waiting room alone was the size of an average house. Actually, this wasn't even Mr. Brim's permanent office. The secretary told me that he worked in London, so what I'd seen was the place he hung his hat on business trips.

The trading room at Salomon Brothers is what you'd get if you suspended a football field 45 floors above the street, and covered it with desks, telephones, and computers. The room itself is at least 100 yards long, with another 30 yards from floor-to-ceiling, so an average punt would never reach the acoustical tile. Tennis lobbs could make their full arcs here, and birds would never know they'd been left indoors.

Around the perimeter of the upper wall at both ends of the floor, where a scoreboard might normally be hung, was the biggest ticker tape I'd seen to date. As it moved along, it sounded like an uncoiled bicycle chain being pulled across the sprockets. Above the background noise, a loudspeaker announced: "Twenty Million Ginnie Maes," and also "Nine percent at 116, let's go guys" in the same way that shoppers are notified of sales at K Mart. There was an occasional squeal or cheer from traders at their desks, and I could pick out bits of the conversation. "I'll trade out of my fuckin' nickel for a bunch" is one phrase I wrote down.

These traders looked like recent college graduates, so I wasn't surprised to hear various whooped obscenities or to see one practical joker pull a chair from under his neighbor, while another trapped his partner in a headlock.

There must have been 200 desks, some with one computer screen